Meanwhile, Back At The Castle...

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/81896926.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Queen Lyra/General Askar

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Original Characters

Additional Tags:
Darkfluff, Fluff and Angst, Of Wing and Claw Universe

Language:
English

Series:
Part 16 of Of Wing and Claw, Part 4 of Of Wing and Claw side stories

Stats:
Published: 2026-03-26 Completed: 2026-03-29 Words: 7,340 Chapters: 3/3

Meanwhile, Back At The Castle...

Posted originally on the Archive of Our Own at https://archiveofourown.org/works/81896926.

Rating:
Teen And Up Audiences

Archive Warning:
No Archive Warnings Apply

Category:
F/M

Fandom:
She-Ra and the Princesses of Power (2018)

Relationship:
Queen Lyra/General Askar

Characters:
Catra (She-Ra), Original Characters

Additional Tags:
Darkfluff, Fluff and Angst, Of Wing and Claw Universe

Language:
English

Series:
Part 16 of Of Wing and Claw, Part 4 of Of Wing and Claw side stories

Stats:
Published: 2026-03-26 Completed: 2026-03-29 Words: 7,340 Chapters: 3/3

Meanwhile, Back At The Castle...

by Paganaidd

Summary

Ariel returns and the news is dire: Snows has fallen.
The unassailable ice kingdom is in the Horde's hands.
Catra is missing.

Chapter 1: Meanwhile, Back at Halfmoon

Chapter Summary

Ariel brings word of Snow's fall.

Chapter Notes

TheNotebookWizard has graciously invited me to play in the Defiance universe! I am delighted to be here.

Half Moon

The Queen's bedroom

Three and a half years after Catra's abduction

"Lyra?" Askar's sleep roughened voice and a gentle shake roused her. "Someone's knocking."

The Queen's eyes opened, waking instantly.

"Your Majesty?" Cloudfoot's voice. Urgent and strained.

A glance at the clock: far too early for anyone to be banging on her door for anything less than a dire emergency.

"What is it?" Lyra called through the door. "Do you need me dressed or will a robe do?"

"Some of Catra's expedition have returned."

Lyra sat up in bed, turning to Askar, his one eye sharp and his ears back with the implication of Cloudfoot's words.

Catra's *expedition* had returned.

“Catra?” Lyra squeaked, jumping out of bed in one motion. “Is she..?”

A pause. A beat long enough to turn blood to ice.

“Catra is... not with them.”

Her throat closed up, as though she had been thrown into deep water. Naked, she stood in the middle of her bedroom, heart racing, unable to force a word from her mouth.

“Akrash is… “ Cloudfoot continued.

“I’m here.” The royal sorcerer’s voice cut across Cloudfoot’s, interrupting him, his voice ragged, rough with fear. “Ariel’s with me. She’s come back, Your Majesty. She has reports.”

Ariel.

Ariel came with reports.

And they frightened Akrash.

With the same speed and precision of donning his armor, Askar hauled on his shirt and the soft pants he usually slept in, while Lyra tried to break out of her shock.

Her robe fell about her shoulders; she hadn’t even noticed Askar retrieve it from the floor. She shrugged her arms into it, tied the waist and yanked the door open.

Her private council stood in the little sitting room across the hall in their nightclothes. Only Percival missing; he would be in the kitchenette starting the kettle for tea.

For a split second, Lyra glanced up at Askar. He gave her a tight encouraging smile and grasped her hand, just for a moment. Some of the ice in her chest melted. She strode into her sitting room, with him falling into step half-a-step behind her.

Akrash stood next to Ariel, his arm about her waist.

The woman looked *terrible.* Her red hair, lank and damp, stuck to her temples and neck. Thinner than Lyra had ever seen her*.* Bordering on gaunt. How did she get so thin, so fast?

A miasma of adrenaline and dried blood clung to her travel stained cloak and she sagged against her brother.

"Your Majesty," Ariel gasped, raising her head, deep circles of exhaustion and pain under both eyes.

Taking in the implications of her state, Lyra felt her blood run cold. "Where's Kesi?"

She couldn't bring herself to ask about Catra. Not yet.

"Safe. I sent her to Mystacor." Ariel croaked. "I sent her to my mom."

Lyra clutched at the collar of her robe. "Why?"

The sorceress held a bundle in her arms, hugging it tightly. She took a deep breath. "Your Majesty. The Kingdom of Snows has fallen to the Horde."

A profound silence followed the pronouncement. Ears tilted back and tails flicked, but otherwise they stood motionless.

Lyra found her voice. "Fallen?"

"Yes."

The sorceress coughed wetly, covering it with the inside of her elbow before continuing.

"And… And Catra… She went with Princess Frosta. They… Well, I'm not sure what they did, but they were heading to the Eastern Pass." She coughed again and hugged the bundle more tightly

with the other arm, as though holding herself together. "Imella and I… We saw the explosion before we teleported out."

"What… do you mean? I thought you said…"

"The victory cost the Horde dearly." Ariel wiped her cheek on her shoulder. "Catra delayed long enough to warn us. She was with…"

A quick intake of breath, perhaps a hiss of pain, broke the sentence, but she went on.

"... a man we met before we reached Snows." Another breath. "He was fighting the Horde. Duncan of Eternos. He went to help Catra with whatever plan she had."

"*Duncan*?" Askar asked, coming up behind Lyra, gripping her shoulder with his strong hand. "An Eternian? Are you sure?"

"Yes." Ariel blinked up at the tall magicat. "That's what he said. He'd been a prisoner of the Horde. For years."

A shiver went around the room at the words, but before they could question it further, Ariel held out the bundle.

"He knew Adora. *Catra's* Adora." Ariel stepped forward to give it to Lyra. "Kesi told me… Not to lose this. She put it in my pack. She said… She said Catra would need it."

Taking it in her hands, Lyra shook it out: a Horde cadet captain jacket. The same kind as the one Aster had so thoughtlessly given Catra years ago.

Too much information; Lyra struggled to process it.

Snows had fallen.

The unassailable ice kingdom. In the Horde's hands.

And Catra?

Lost?

Hands- Askar's?- steered her to sit in her favorite chair.

Her claws kneaded into the red jacket. Like that terrible night so many years ago. The days and months afterward. The aftermath of the coup attempt, when she'd sat in this very chair. Listening to reports list the missing and the dead.

And her husband. Her fathers. Her sisters. Her baby.

Gone.

In one night. An orphan. A widow. A childless mother. Bereft.

Alone.

The room spun, leaving her sick and afraid. The past and present blurred together as she relived the moment hope had been snuffed out of her life.

But, she had received revelation that night: Hope was a luxury for those who could afford to wait.

As Queen, she could and *would* live without hope.

The long-ago resolution steadied her.

Yes.

One breath. Two.

Focus. No time for weakness.

She was the Queen. Bonded to the Spirit Ember. Protector of Halfmoon.

Lyra did not need hope. She had *meaning.*

Purpose.

The scene sharpened as she regained control over her runaway emotions. In the sudden clarity, she saw the sorceress sway on her feet and Akrash tighten his arm around her waist.

"Ariel." Lyra rasped. "Sit."

The young woman collapsed onto the low sofa. The others in the room took it as a signal to find their own seats. Askar grabbed a foot stool and sat down right next to her chair. So tall that it put his head level with hers.

"Your Majesty," whispered Ariel. "When I last spoke to her, Catra said she was going to find her way home."

Find her way home? Of course. She had to.

But if she didn't…

Lyra gripped the jacket with her claws.

Her child.

Her *heart*.

Her daughter's scent lingered on the jacket: amber, cinnamon. The warm leather and metal of her armor. Apples. Honey. Coppery notes from her magic and the hot scent of the Spirit Ember.

So much salt.

Catra had worn this jacket, wept into it. But the dominant scent belonged to a stranger.

Lyra looked up from the jacket to meet Ariel's eyes. "Adora? Is she alive?"

"We… don't know. Duncan said they escaped the Horde. He thought so. He was looking for her." The woman swallowed and pointed with her chin. "He had that. Kesi preserved her scent on it."

Lyra looked back down at the jacket.

Heedless of the crowd gathered in her rooms to hear Ariel's tale, Lyra buried her face in the fabric, surrounding herself. Breathing the new scent into her being. Fixing it into her memory. Picking out the layers the way she did with her daughter's scent.

Magic. The same deep golden magic hidden in Catra's core. *Lauha* wood. Apples and cinnamon.

The scent of Catra's essence in the stranger's heart.

No question then. Not that there ever was one.

If Adora lived, Lyra would find her. Save her. She owed her daughter that.

When she sat up, someone pushed a cup of hot tea into her hand. The exact right temperature for drinking. Sweet with honey that could not quite cover the bitterness of Lenio's restoratives. It helped clear her head.

"Now. What happened?"

Ariel took a long breath, pulling her cloak around her and leaning into her brother's side. She shivered as though with a deep cold.

"After Catra sent the scouts back with the injured …"

For the next half hour, Ariel spoke steadily, her voice soft and rough, picking up from the last reports they'd gotten from those scouts. Outlining their meeting with the stranger, their arrival in Snows. Saving Frosta from the betrayal of her regents and kidnapping by the Horde.

The child had been bound to the Fractal Flake as a toddler. By the will of the nobles.

Lenio sucked in a harsh breath, and Lyra saw Percival reach for Cloudfoot's hand as Ariel described the Princess' situation.

A mere babe. Bonded to a runestone. At the behest of people who had no understanding of what the bonding would do to her.

That alone would have made Lyra want to go to her aid. Her heart swelled with pride as Ariel spoke of how Catra took the child into her heart.

Snow's regents turned the kingdom over to the Horde.

Every ear pinned, every tail lashed. Gasps and small exclamations of dismay rippled around the room as they heard how Catra's forces had been ambushed and defeated.

Catra had never been defeated.

"So… Kesi had my crystal. We were… cornered. I triggered the spell and then Imella and I teleported out."

Lyra shook her head. "You and Imella? But, where are the rest?" She trailed off, realizing she knew the answer to that question.

Forehead slick with sweat, Ariel shivered in the warm room. The redhead's furless skin always seemed too pale, but now her cheeks were almost gray. The brown spots scattered across her face showed up in stark contrast. The scent of fresh blood overwhelmed the dried.

Akrash turned to look at his sister, his eyes wide, his pupils thin slits. "Ariel?"

"Something's… wrong. I think," whispered Ariel, putting her arms around her midsection.

Akrash moved to pull Ariel's cloak aside but Lenio jumped up from his chair in the corner.

"No, lad. Let me. You just keep her upright." The old doctor told Akrash, getting down on one knee. "Don't let her fall."

“No. Never.” Akrash whispered the words. Lyra didn't think he meant to say them out loud.

“Something *popped,”* Ariel muttered, gritting her teeth.

Kittrina stood from her place on the settee next to Aster, to take Ariel’s cloak and put her hand on Akrash’s shoulder as he prevented Ariel from sliding onto the floor.

New blood stained the inside of the cloak and a growing wet patch, bright red with fresh blood, spread on her shirt.

Lenio swore as he pulled up her shirt. The odor of infection wafted through the room. “How long have you had this?”

“Three… three weeks?” The words were breathy and faint. The blood scent strong. “The battle where Catra rescued Frosta. I was stabbed.”

Beside Lyra, Askar let out a long hiss.

“This was stitched?”

“Yeah… It’s been okay, but I think I might have torn something?”

“And the infection?”

“Infection? That’s new.” Ariel opened glossy eyes.

Akrash’s ears were pinned tight to his skull. He pulled a handkerchief from somewhere and mopped Ariel’s face. “You’re feverish.”

Incongruously, Ariel huffed a chuckle. “You… you still use *lace* handkerchiefs.”

“Hush. They make me look distinguished.” The tremor in the man’s voice belied the flippant words. It sounded like an old joke between the two. “Your fault for buying them.”

“Come on. Let's get her to the infirmary.” Lenio told Akrash. “This infection is moving too fast.”

“Too fast?” Askar seized on that for some reason.

Lenio nodded. “An infection this serious? I would have smelled it when I walked in. I *know* it wasn’t this bad half an hour ago.”

Askar grunted. “I’m not a healer or a sorcerer, but you need to look for poisons.”

Lyra went cold and Lenio turned to stare at the general.

“Poisons?” The old doctor demanded.

“Seen this before. The Snakemen make a poison that they use on their blades. The healers told me that it needs magic to heal it. The sorcerer's magic gets diverted to it. Puts them out of commission for weeks. The minute they try to do more than light a candle, their wounds reopen and they get infections.”

Lenio pressed one finger to his forehead and growled to himself. “Wonderful, a whole new way to destroy people.”

He stood. “Your Majesty, if you need to speak with her further, you’ll have to do it with her flat on her back. That wound reopened and we’re going to have to put her guts back in.”

A flurry of movement. Akrash lifted Ariel’s limp form in his arms.

The two strode out into the hallway and closed the door behind them.

No one spoke.

Lyra held the empty cup in her hands, with the jacket on her lap. Her mind blanked, sucked clean of every thought.

Askar took the cup from her hands and handed it to Percival. He squeezed her shoulder again. For a fraction of a second, she let

herself lean into that strength.

Cloudfoot exchanged a glance with Percival. Aster’s eyebrows knitted briefly. Her relationship with Askar wasn’t exactly a secret from her closest advisors, but she had not been ready to discuss it. Percival, bless his fuzzy heart, had put a breakfast meeting with her military advisor onto every day of her calendar.

Kittrina threw herself into Aster’s arms, sobbing as her husband rubbed her back. Cloudfoot and Percival sat together, their hands clasped, eyes over bright.

No tears leaked from Lyra's eyes. Not yet. “Where’s Isha?” Lyra asked.

“Home. Asleep,” Aster answered. “Rogelio’s guarding her.”

Good. The tiny princess was well-protected. The succession was guaranteed.

“We’ll convene the full Council an hour after first light.” Lyra’s voice sounded hollow and far away, but firm. “Cloudfoot? Can you see to it?"

“Yes, of course, Your Majesty.” Cloudfoot stood, gave her a half bow, and then swept out of the room.

“Kittrina? I will need you at the council meeting. I will remind them that you are the designated Regent, should I need to leave the city. I will name who shall be appointed as your chief advisors, if it should come to that.”

The woman jumped. “Majesty?” Kittrina whispered, her eyes wide, blinking rapidly.

“As Isha’s mother, you are to be regent, not Cloudfoot. And not the Council, nor any of the other nobles.”

Halfmoon would stand. Now and always.

“Go. See your daughter. Find some food. I have no doubt we will have a long day in the Council chambers.”

Aster and Kittrina shared a worried glance, but they both gave her little bows, acknowledging her words before they followed her orders.

Percival brought in a tea tray from the kitchen, with a cold breakfast that he placed on the little table. He nodded at Lyra and Askar, picking up his tablet before he left the room.

Askar passed Lyra a plate of bread and meat and another cup of tea. “You need to eat something yourself.”

Before Lyra could reply, someone banged on the front door to her rooms.

Askar rolled his eyes. “Let me deal with it.”

He crossed back through the sitting room and around the corner. The front door opened

“Askar!!” Imoh’s voice.

Damn. Lyra thought she’d have at least three hours before she had to deal with him.

“You’re already here. Good. So Ariel reported to the Queen?”

“Yes.” Lyra imagined Askar looming over Imoh with his arms crossed, as he had the day of Catra’s Ascension when he’d threatened to feed Imoh’s heart to him. “The Council is meeting an hour after first light.” His voice dropped, low and threatening. “And I promise you, if you work against us…”

“No! I… ” The man swallowed. “Fires Below, Askar! Imella arrived at my door, an hour ago, covered in blood.”

“What?” Few things could startle Askar, but Lyra heard it in his voice. “Was she injured?”

“No.” A pause. “It wasn’t her blood.”

Askar didn’t say anything. He understood the value of silence as well as Lyra did.

“She… Ariel… Imella said Ariel saved her life. Catra ordered them to flee, to get back here any way they could.”

“The Horde’s sorcerers chased them through two teleportations. Imella told Ariel to just leave her to deal with them. To just get the news back to us.”

“What happened?”

“Ariel refused to leave her.” Imoh sounded like a man whose world had shattered. “Before the Council meeting I want to tell Her Majesty, she has my full support.” Imoh paused. “I just needed Her Majesty to know that.”

“I will be sure to pass that on.”

Lyra could imagine Imoh’s face at the non-answer.

“Now, if you do not mind.” Askar continued with the dogged patience of a man determined to keep his temper in check. “Her Majesty and I were in a military advisor’s meeting.

“Of course. I will see you at the meeting.”

The door closed and Lyra heard Askar blow out his breath in a long sigh.

“That was… interesting,” he said wryly, as he returned.

Something in her chest unwound at the sound of Askar's voice. Lyra dismissed Imoh from her mind. Without a word, clutching the jacket to her chest, she stood, returning to her bedroom. Askar followed her, closing the bedroom door and sitting on the bed to watch her.

She knelt on the floor next to her dresser. A flat keepsake box made of *lauha* wood met her fingers. This box sat untouched for fifteen years. Catra knew it existed, but they both shied away from looking at it.

Kneeling on the floor, Lyra opened it. The scent drifting out nearly broke her.

Amber and cinnamon. Apples and honey.

The same scent and yet not. The sweetness of a slumbering child instead of the sweat and tears of a warrior

She folded the precious jacket. Bespelled to keep the scents fresh, the box reinforced the tailor's spell. It would be safe here next to the soft blue blanket. A promise to her daughter.

Lyra did not need hope.

Once again, she would choose meaning. She would choose purpose.

Her breath caught in her throat and she wrapped her arms around herself.

"Lyra?" Askar came to kneel next to her.

She picked up the blanket, held it in her hands. "When I lost Cyrus. When I lost *her*. I became too cautious. Too easily swayed." She bit her lip. "When we found his body, I talked myself into believing that Catra..."

She sniffed.

"The night Akrash brought her in, I didn't go to her right away to see for myself. I let them talk me into letting Arashu handle it."

"And then, her first weeks here, before the coup attempt, I let the council bully me into dealing with her how *they* wanted."

Askar scoffed. “And see how that turned out for them.”

“She shouldn’t have had to fight so hard. I should have…” she jumped to her feet, pacing the length of the room. Askar moved to sit on the bed and followed her with his eyes.

“I let them play political games and posture at each other instead of taking the matter into my own hands.” She shook her head. “I knew I made a mistake.”

“I never opened that box. I could never face how I failed her.” She clenched her fists. “I let them convince me. For the sake of peace and prosperity!” Her hands dropped to her sides. “I knew then I was a coward. I never saw a body. I let all of the Council’s ‘wisdom’ overrule that fact.”

Askar stood, shaking his head. “Lyra, no. I remember what it was like when we found Cyrus’ body. We searched for days. Remember? *I* thought she was dead. We all did.”

He took her hands in both of his.

”You knew there was no one else who could take the throne. No one else could bond to the Spirit Ember and defend us. You did it for your people.”

This time Lyra would not count Catra among the dead until she saw the body, no matter what any of them said. Nothing would hold her back. Not the Council, not her friends, not the traitors, not her grief, not her duty. She would find her daughter, or she would find incontrovertible proof of her death.

And if that happened Lyra would have nothing left to lose.

The Horde would remember why they feared her.

The sound of the sob surprised her. “I can’t do this,” she wailed, holding the blanket to her face.

Askar put his arm across her shoulders.

“I can’t do this again. Not alone.”

“Lyra.” The arm tightened, drawing her closer, one hand stroked her cheek, encouraging her to look up. “You’re not alone.”

His familiar battle scarred face looked down at her, his one eye filled with compassion. Empathy. Friendship.

Love?

Her breath caught in her chest as he leaned to touch his forehead to hers. She breathed him in, letting his scent settle her. Letting his strength support her.

“Askar… what if she’s gone?”

A long moment and then, “Ariel mentioned a man named Duncan. An Eternian.”

“Yes.”

“If he is the same Duncan I knew, and she is with him, she is as safe as she could possibly be. We were trained by the same *ahran*.”

Lyra moved back to look at Askar. “Do you think it could be?”

“There are damned few Eternians on Etheria, so yes.”

“If she was with this Duncan, where would he go?”

Askar rubbed his cheek. “The Qadians are secretive. Our portal is not common knowledge on Eternos.”

“Catra doesn’t know that.”

“No. And my guess is that she will offer him Halfmoon’s hospitality.” A slow smile came over his face. “And they will be making their way here by the shortest route.”

“So you think you can find him?”

“I think so.”

“And Catra?”

“If he lives she’ll be with him. And if he lives he’ll give his life to protect her.”

Askar didn’t offer hope. He offered *possibility.*

Her mind lurched into motion as she looked down at the blanket. Then she stood to retrieve the box. Gently, reverently, she tucked it next to the jacket and closed the lid, resting her hand on it for a few heartbeats before she shut it in the drawer.

Straightening, she turned back to Askar. “The Council cannot argue with me on this. With The Kingdom of Snows gone, we are next.” She tapped her chin then moved to retrieve her tablet from her desk.

“What are you doing?”

“Ordering Percival to take out my armor. The Council may need a visual aid.” The stylus danced across the screen as she sent out the message. “How long would it take you to organize a force to march to Snows to find Catra?”

“Tonight, if we start preparing now.”

She looked up. “Get what forces you need. Arrange it. Find my daughter.”

Chapter 2: News

Halfmoon Castle

Council Chambers

Three and a Half Years after Catra's abduction.

"Askar?" Imoh stood stiffly at the door, hanging back from the other Councilors as they bustled out. "A word please?" He turned back into the empty Council room.

Halfmoon's general growled to himself, but followed the old man. True to his word, Imoh had supported Lyra's plans for Askar to take a small force to look for Catra and find out what had happened. When Lenio reported that Ariel wasn't available, he had even called Imella to speak to the Council directly instead of relying on written reports.

Hearing the stoic fighter so shaken had done half the work for them. The content of her report did the rest.

Now Imoh stood in the doorway, waiting. It was time to find the price of his help.

"General, we have not always seen eye-to-eye but…"

"I don't have time for this Minister."

"Right then, of course. I'll speak plainly." Imoh straightened. "Your relationship with Her Majesty…"

Oh, Askar was not going to take that this time of the morning. Whatever reservations the old fool had, he could choke on them.

"Is not your concern."

"You misunderstand me." Imoh swallowed and looked around, as though verifying no one stood near. "I do not have as much

influence in my faction as I once had, but I wanted you to know, you and she have my full support."

Askar stopped cold, feeling a bit like he'd been hit with a spell to cause confusion.

The shorter man leaned in, his voice dropping. "I realize you might not have thought about it, but at this time, the last thing Her Majesty should have is concern that the legitimacy of the succession will be questioned. Halfmoon needs it clear."

"What…?" Only a lifetime of discipline prevented Askar from taking the old man's throat into both hands. "Don't you dare imply that Catra…"

"Catra?!" Imoh's face blanked and then he seemed to comprehend. "General, we're speaking at cross purposes. I'm talking about Her Majesty's current pregnancy."

"Current. Pregnancy."

Imoh's eyes widened. "Oh. General. My apologies." He seemed genuinely remorseful. "I am so sorry. I hadn't thought…" He shook his head. "I am an old man, I have had five children." He stopped to consider. "I have also always had a gift for discerning these things."

"Pregnancy? Lyra?"

Imoh turned and shut the door. "Yes, General." He made little 'calm down' motions with his hands as he stepped closer.

"That's not… possible."

Was it possible? Lyra and he had not discussed this. He assumed… Well, obviously he *had* to assume this was a temporary liaison. Just for now. Two old friends finding comfort with each other.

Since Cyrus' death, Lyra had refused all suitors. All liaisons even. Holding everyone at arms length. Before Catra's return, Imoh had practically begged Lyra to make a political marriage. To anyone. She was still young.

Imoh brought it up at least three times a year. Askar privately thought that the pressure made it *less* likely that Lyra would move on from Cyrus, her imprinted husband.

Imprinted.

These last few years, the word haunted both dreams and daydreams.

Imprinted.

He'd never spoken it aloud. Only ever thought about in his most private thoughts.

When Catra arrived, it took the pressure from Lyra to produce a new heir.

And then, Kittrina had supplied a second heir that could bond to the Spirit Ember. Kittrina's own ability to connect to it confirmed her place as Presumptive Regent.

Was it possible for the mere removal of all that pressure..?

Imprints were tricky things. No one really understood them. No one knew if imprint magic caused the feelings or if the feelings caused the imprint. He'd heard stories that they could be disrupted by sorcery, prevented by grief. Stories of people who pined after their someone, only to look up one day and find themselves connected.

It was well-known that imprinted couples had an easier time conceiving. Most accidental pregnancies came from imprints.

Imoh stood silently, his hands tucked behind his back while Askar reeled with the implications.

A slow smile came over his face and he focused on Imoh. “You’re sure?”

Imoh nodded. “I… have a little foresight. I am completely certain.” His mouth turned up at the corners. “Let me be the first to offer my congratulations. Since we do not want any question of legitimacy I suggest a secret marriage.”

“Excuse me?”

“A little cultural sleight-of-hand, if you will.”

The minister smiled at his own joke.

“The secret marriage is a time honored way to accommodate a newly acknowledged imprint if the child might come a little too soon after the wedding. Her Majesty only needs someone to bear witness. I will testify to this.”

“Newly. Imprinted?”

Imoh raised an eyebrow and his tail curled at the end. The old bastard enjoyed this.

“Oh. My. Did you think I didn’t notice? You spent the entire meeting anticipating the Queen’s every move.” He broke into a full grin. “And for once, she allowed it.”

Askar had known. Fires, he’d known. But as Lyra didn’t speak, he couldn’t.

“General?” Imoh patted Askar’s upper arm to reclaim his attention. “I fear I have spoken out of turn twice in this conversation. Again, I apologize.”

`“I need to speak to Lyra.” Askar was a warrior. He understood how to compartmentalize. How to go to battle when his heart stayed behind.

But he needed certainty.

“Of course.” Imoh bowed and gave him that wide (in a military camp, Askar would have called it shit-eating) grin. “Again, you have my congratulations.”

The tablet pinged: Askar’s tone.

Meet me in the infirmary.

Ariel must be awake.

Kittrina held Isha against her shoulder, purring and patting her back. The debate in the Council took less time than Lyra feared. The shock of the news did all the work. But Lyra felt absolutely ragged.

Quietly, so as not to wake Isha. “That was Askar. He needs me.” Lyra stood, and Kittrina nodded. They had finished anyway.

The Council had approved Askar's mission without serious opposition. Imella's report had seen to that. They radiated almost palpable relief at the idea that it kept Lyra in the city until the reports came back.

Lyra nodded at Rogelio as she swept out. Her guards fell into step behind her.

Askar waited for her in the foyer of the infirmary, leading her to one of the side rooms Lenio used for conferences, closing the door behind them.

“What’s wrong?”

“I just came from speaking with Imoh…”

Lyra snorted and crossed her arms, wondering what the man wanted for his support.

“Lyra." Askar pressed his hands on the table, looking far more worried than Imoh usually made him. "Is there… Could there be… Is there any chance you could be pregnant?”

“I… No. I… “ Her hand dropped to her belly, splaying wide beneath her navel. It felt *heavy.*

Since Cyrus died, she had felt a stillness in herself. A gloom that nothing could lift, try as she might. Her people needed her to be the Queen after the coup had nearly broken them, so she had done what she must. All of her pain safely locked away in the dresser.

She had *been* the Queen.

Catra’s return had restored something of herself that she had thought lost. Watching Catra struggle to remain *Catra,* even as everyone tried to sculpt her into what they thought the Princess should be, had woken something within her.

A fierce desire to find *Lyra* again.

For those first months she had carved out time with her daughter. Hours in the day where she was able to be her daughter’s mother. Protecting her. Helping her, teaching her.

As time went on and Catra needed her less, she had jealously guarded that time, but now for herself.

In that negative space, in that time, she had found herself weeping for Cyrus. Raging at him. Begging his shade for forgiveness.

Mourning him.

Only a few ever saw those tears. Lenio, Percival, Cloudfoot.

Askar.

Her general. Always correct. Supportive. Loyal. He held her when she wept, sat through her silences and watched her throw fire at the walls in her fury.

They had shared many a bottle of wine over the years. But since Catra had returned, they had become something else. The nights of planning were outnumbered by nights when they laughed together, their eyes meeting over the rim of his glass, and she felt like a girl again.

And these last few weeks…

"We need to talk to Lenio." She sent the message on her tablet and pulled up her calendar. Her cycle had been like clockwork, four times a year since Cyrus died, and she had not done anything to prevent it.

She *was* late.

In three minutes, the old doctor came in. "I'm afraid Ariel's still…"

"I need a pregnancy test." Lyra cut him off before he could finish.

The furrowing of his brows was the only sign of surprise. "All right."

Every room in the infirmary could be used for patient care, so they were all fully stocked. He took the little packages of sterile equipment to take blood out of the drawer. Lyra understood; Lenio always used the most reliable tests even if they took a few minutes longer. "Do you have any idea how far along you might be?"

"I'm a few weeks late, I think."

Askar's eyebrows went up. "You never said…"

Lyra shook her head. "I didn't notice. Until recently, I haven't had much reason to do anything other than note it on the calendar to order supplies."

That shelf had not been refilled for a while.

Lenio nodded curtly, while Lyra extended her arm across the table. He shaved a little patch into the fur inside her elbow and then tied on the tourniquet. She grimaced at the sting and kept still until he removed the needle and put a bandage on it.

He collected everything from the table. “I’ll be right back.” The man strode out of the room, closing the door behind him.

Neither of them spoke. Lyra’s leg jumped under the table, the only sign of agitation she allowed herself. Askar reached out and covered her hand with his.

The silence felt fragile as it stretched and they avoided each other’s eyes.

Neither of them had much use for hope. They clung to certainty. To action. That was why they understood each other.

Lenio’s footsteps outside the door. A pause. When he opened the door his expression was perfectly neutral.

He sat at the table. “The test is positive, Your Majesty.”

“You are certain?” Lyra could not help but ask.

“I am.” Lenio looked between the two of them. “So, before we go any further, I need to know. Is this good news or bad news?”

Lyra’s eyes sought Askar’s. Catra was missing. They were at war. The world was falling about their ears.

“It is *wonderful* news,” she blurted before she could think.

Askar’s smile mirrored hers and he took both of her hands.

Now Lenio grinned. “About damned time something went right around here.”

“Askar? How did you know? What made you think to call me down here?”

“Imoh knows. He cornered me after the Council meeting. “

“How?”

“He said he could tell. And he was worried that the council would have trouble with the legitimacy of the heir.”

Lyra bared her teeth. “Oh, no. He does not get to…”

Askar raised his hands in a placating gesture. “He wanted to make sure this child was counted as legitimate.”

“Oh.” A sharp intake of breath. The Council, damn them, *would* make a fuss.

“Imoh has offered to testify to a secret marriage.”

“A secret marriage.” The sheer absurdity made Lyra chuckle. “What, like in a Founding-era Romance?”

“Why not?” Lenio nodded. “People love a good story.” He smiled lopsidedly. “We could use the morale boost.”

“He's not wrong.” Askar's eyes crinkled at the corners. “Better a romance than a scandal.”

“So, you’d be willing…?” Lyra’s breath caught, her mind catching up to what she was asking.

Proposing.

Askar’s smile softened and he reclaimed her hands. “Lyra. Of course. I just never thought…” he cut himself off with a glance at Lenio who was busy with his tablet. “Whatever you need to do to make it work politically, I'm willing.”

“We can’t announce this yet, anyway.” Lyra sobered. “I want to find out what happened in Snows first. I want to know what we’re

up against.”

“Agreed.” Askar squeezed Lyra’s hand.

“And… I don't want to announce it before I tell Catra.” Lyra twisted her fingers around Askar’s. “Is that stupid?”

“No.” He scooted his chair over so he could pull her into a hug.

Lyra moved to put her arms around Askar and for a moment it felt strange. Clumsy and awkward.

New.

The moment passed and she rested against his shoulder. “Be careful,” she murmured. “Come back soon.”

“I will. I’ll bring Catra home and then we can have all the stupid announcements and festivities the Council could want.” His words were light, but Lyra felt him tremble.

He backed up and smiled down at her before he swept from the room.

Chapter 3: Secrets

Chapter Summary

Plans are put in motion.
Secrets are kept.

Halfmoon

Infirmary

Three and a half years since Catra's abduction.

Lyra turned back to Lenio, a little embarrassed, although she knew the old doctor would never judge her.

"I already sent for Percival." the doctor told her. "I don't want you walking out of here until we have a plan." His tail lashed. "I'll need to do a full exam at your earliest convenience. I'll order some vitamins too."

"I don't think I need to tell you this time might be harder than last time." Lenio met her eyes. "But we can talk about that in a few weeks. One crisis at a time.

A knock on the door interrupted him.

"Come in!" called Lenio.

Percival bustled in, tablet in hand. "Your Majesty." He half bowed and looked quizzically at them both. "What can I do for you? I had assumed Ariel…"

"No, Ariel's still out." Lenio's mouth pinched. "We had to do a major repair. Akrash is with her." He pointed with his chin at the other chair. "You should have a seat. Her Majesty has some news."

The seneschal's eyebrows went up. But he nodded and sat with folded hands.

Lyra licked her dry lips. No way to cushion or soften the news. "I'm pregnant."

Percival stared at her without speaking. Slowly he turned his head to look at Lenio and then back.

"It's… Askar and I… Well, you know." Lyra shifted in her chair, her throat suddenly thick. "It's terrible timing. We need to keep the Council from making life difficult."

Speaking too fast, trying to get it all out before it caught up with her.

"Imoh already knows. He guessed. He told Askar that he would swear that he witnessed our secret marriage. We can announce it after Catra's home. I want to tell her first."

Percival's eyes widened and he cleared his throat. "Your Majesty." His hand pressed against his chest and his voice shook."Your Majesty."

He couldn't continue, tears rolled down his cheeks and he searched his pocket for a handkerchief to mop his face. "I'm sorry. This is so unexpected."

Lyra felt her mouth turn up at the corners. Her chest warm, she leaned over to pat her seneschal's hand.

"Imoh's secret marriage plan has merit," Lenio told them after a pause. "And if you backdate it about four weeks, that lines up."

"How could we do that?" Lyra asked, a little irritated with herself for not thinking this could happen. "Will people accept it?"

"A secret marriage?" Percival sniffed and cleared his throat, reaching for his tablet, eyes narrowing in thought. "That Lord Imoh will swear he witnessed? Hm."

He picked up his stylus, tapping it on the table.

“Well… Kesi *is* a priestess. She *could* have married you secretly before she left with Catra. I have Kesi’s seal in my office for the certificate. And I can find a plausible date in Your Majesty’s calendar.” He smiled faintly. “I doubt anyone would dare ask Kesi about it.”

He scribbled some notes, becoming more excited as he spoke.

“This is hardly unprecedented. A new imprint coming on you and Askar suddenly? We're at war. It would make sense that you didn’t want to make an announcement or a fuss. You didn’t tell anyone because you didn’t want the pressure of conceiving. Imoh is the logical witness, since he has been hounding you to marry for years.”

Blinking rapidly, Lyra stared, once again in awe of Percival’s quick political thinking.

“Have I left anything out?” Percival looked between Lyra and Lenio.

“No.”

He opened her public calendar that the staff used. “Backdated four weeks? Perfect. You had a morning meeting with Askar. I’ll just add Kesi and Imoh to the record.” He smiled. “I'll put a few traditional wedding items in the order. The servants will remember that you ordered some pastries from Tathlan’s. But I’m the only one who would bring you your wedding jewelry or the wine.”

Lyra nodded. People were bound to look at her records to see *when* it happened*..*

“We’ll need to make the announcement before you start to show, but you have a few weeks. We'll announce the marriage and the pregnancy at the same time.”

He tapped his stylus on the table again. “I’ll talk to Cloudfoot about the coronation of Askar as King-Consort. We’ll have to throw a gala, even if it’s got to be a short one.”

Lyra could not help but smile ruefully. “Oh no! A gala she *mus*t attend. Catra will never forgive me.”

Halfmoon Castle
Royal Residence

Three and a half years after Catra’s abduction

“Did you see that Her Majesty saw Dr. Lenio this afternoon?” Margo asked Shell as they cleaned the corridor outside Queen Lyra’s bedroom. “She was there for a long time.”

“You know that’s not our business.” The other cleaner shrugged. “Anyway, she was probably just checking on Ariel.”

“Lenio sent a note to stock some new vitamins in the Queen’s cupboard.” Margo dropped it casually, watching Shell for her reaction. “I took them in. They were prenatal ones.”

Shell grunted, but didn’t reply.

Margo understood. Gossip about the royal family was strongly discouraged and no one *ever* wanted to get in trouble with Princess Catra’s seneschal, Kesi. But everyone knew General Askar had been having breakfast meetings with Queen Lyra ever since Princess Catra left.

All of Queen Lyra’s staff had been studiously ignoring the evidence that General Askar had been staying overnight. They all knew how not to see.

But prenatal vitamins? And the new appointments with Dr. Lenio added to the Queen’s calendar this morning? That went beyond the pale.

Margo had worked for the royal family for almost ten years and remembered the whispers of a succession crisis should something happen to the queen. An illegitimate child in the royal family could cause another.

When they took their break, Margo took out her small tablet and checked Her Majesty's schedule; she had to be mistaken.

There: war advisory meetings with the general, every morning.

But when she scrolled back to the *first* meeting, weeks ago, the entry was written in *gold* font.

Advsry Mtg.

Gn Askar, Ld Imoh, Snchl Kesi.

Meetings in gold always signified a ceremony. With a rising sense of hope, Margo clicked on the supply requisition.

And sucked her breath in sharply.

An order from Tathlan's bakery. Pastries for two. The ones she had taken up. And more: sparkling honey-wine for two. *Flowers!*

A few notations by Percival that Margo didn't know.

Wddg:

Gblt

Jlry

Cert

She stopped to consider how Percival abbreviated things.

Wedding: Goblet. Jewelry. Certificate.

YES!

Seneschal Kesi was a priestess. Lord Imoh had been after Her Majesty to marry *forever.*

Excited now, she checked the Queen's supply list and verified; she had not ordered any menstrual supplies for *months*.

"Shell! Shell! Shell!" Margo grabbed the other woman's arm while she hopped up and down, knocking over her chair.

"What are you…?"

Margo jabbed her finger at the notation in the calendar. Shell leaned forward, her eyes narrow. "No. Way."

"You see!?" Relief and joy bubbled up in Margo's chest.

"I… yes." Shell's tail lashed.

"Look at the other thing!" Margo pulled up the date Lyra last ordered those supplies.

"Oh. Oh my."

"See!"

Shell grinned. "That's amazing." She glanced around. "But keep it quiet. No one needs to know until Her Majesty announces it. She can't wait too long."

Margo nodded. They'd all been on the receiving end of Seneschal Kesi's "Working for the royal family is a sacred trust" lecture. She didn't need to tell anyone, anyway. Enough that she and Shell

knew, and when the announcement was made, she would know she'd seen it first.

Please drop by the Archive and comment to let the creator know if you enjoyed their work!